

Chapter 71 Part 9

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As dusk fell, the streetlights along the road lit up one after another.

Zhou Yi'an drove to the Su family villa, carrying a cake in her hand.

Sheng Yu was the first to see her. She jumped high, raising her hand and shouting: "Sister An!"

Zhou Yi'an curved her lips into a smile. She pocketed her car keys, handed the cake to a servant, then scooped up Sheng Yu in one motion. Then her arm sank down, and she frowned at Sheng Yu. "Have you gained weight again?"

Sheng Yu's mouth drooped. "No!"

"Kids need to grow." Zhou Yi'an said: "I'm not scolding you."

"But after you say I've gotten heavier, you won't hold me anymore." Sheng Yu hugged her neck and acted spoiled. "Hold me more."

"Hold, hold, hold—" Zhou Yi'an said helplessly, "But don't pull my hair, okay?"

Sheng Yu's eyes rolled around. "Oops, you found out."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

"Obviously." Zhou Yi'an slapped her on the bottom. "You're pulling so hard it hurts."

"Wuwuwu~" Sheng Yu looked aggrieved. "Sister! Sister An hit me."

Su Meiqi happened to come downstairs, wearing her caterpillar-like onesie pajamas with the hood on. Hearing this, she glanced at the fake-crying Sheng Yu. "Why are you calling me? I can't beat her anyway."

Sheng Yu: "..."

Zhou Yi'an sat down holding Sheng Yu, then politely greeted Mr. and Mrs. Su Zhe, and asked about Su Yao's condition.

Before Su Zhe could speak, Su Yao walked out of her room. Her complexion was still somewhat pale, but much better compared to previous years.

She wasn't like in previous years when, at this time, she would be bedridden with constant nightmares.

"Teacher Su." Zhou Yi'an greeted her. Su Yao nodded. "You're here."

After that, the Su family had dinner. Sheng Yu clung to Zhou Yi'an and sat on her lap. Su Meiqi was on the other side.

Zhou Yi'an hadn't even started eating herself when she began feeding Sheng Yu first.

Su Meiqi couldn't help but say: "Sheng Yu, how old are you? Can't you feed yourself?"

Sheng Yu pouted. "I want Sister An to feed me."

Zhou Yi'an fed her a spoonful of rice: "You're really being clingy right now."

Su Meiqi looked at her. "Your patience has really grown."

Zhou Yi'an: "Has it?"

Su Meiqi immediately lowered her head. "You continue."

When Su Yao saw Sheng Yu constantly bothering Zhou Yi'an, she called Sheng Yu's name in a cold voice and told her to eat by herself. Only then did Zhou Yi'an gain her freedom.

While eating, Su Meiqi still wore her hood. The brim was loose and floppy. When she lowered her head, the hood was about to fall into her plate.

Su Zhe glanced at her and was about to scold her when Zhou Yi'an directly reached out and removed her hood, revealing Su Meiqi's frizzy curly hair.

Everyone: "?"

Su Meiqi: "!"

"What are you doing?!" Su Meiqi frantically put her hood back on. "Zhou Yi'an, don't just grab things, okay?"

Zhou Yi'an was also surprised. "What did you do today?"

Su Meiqi: "...Hanging out with friends."

"What kind of questionable friends are you hanging out with now?" Su Zhe said coldly: "I tell you to come to the company and you don't. All you do is run around outside all day, mixing with those bad friends of yours, wearing all sorts of strange outfits and running around everywhere!"

"I didn't." Su Meiqi argued: "I just went to a comic convention¹."

"Anyway, stop doing all that stuff in the future. Come to my company next week." Su Zhe said.

"I'm not going." Su Meiqi said: "I've already found a job and will start work soon. If you don't like seeing me, I'll just move out."

Su Zhe said sternly: "Stop using this to threaten me. What kind of person you are, do you think I don't know? You're definitely lying to me again about finding work, then running off to mess around with those bad friends."

"What do you mean 'bad friends'?" Su Meiqi said: "They're all proper friends. You don't understand young people's world, so don't make baseless criticisms, okay?"

"Yi'an is also a young person. How come she won a Rising Designer award at RT²? How come she found a job? What about you? Apart from messing around all day, what can you do?"

"Uncle." Zhou Yi'an saw the situation turning bad. Under the table, she kicked Su Meiqi, signaling her to say less.

She was about to speak up for Su Meiqi when Su Meiqi jumped up like a mouse whose tail had been stepped on. She kicked Zhou Yi'an back. "If Zhou Yi'an is so great, why don't you recognize her as your daughter? You don't like me anyway."

She pulled her chair aside. "If you like her, make her your daughter. And she's an Alpha too—she's more suitable to inherit your business. See if she's willing to let you be her dad?! I'm the useless one. I'm getting my job offer this week and moving out. I definitely won't stay home and be an eyesore to you!"

Her emotions were too agitated, and her hood fell off.

Her frizzy hair appeared in everyone's view again. She reached up and smoothed it, then turned to go upstairs, but was grabbed by Zhou Yi'an pulling on her pajama tail.

Su Meiqi: "...!!!"

"Let me go." Su Meiqi yelled at her: "Don't pull my tail!"

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She let go, and saw Su Meiqi march upstairs with great vigor.

Sheng Yu, who had been eating with her head down, looked up in confusion at Su Zhe. "Uncle, you scolded Sister again."

Su Zhe was so angry he nearly had a heart attack. "Your sister is scolding me! Calling me stubborn, autocratic, and inflexible."

Sheng Yu: "...What does that mean?"

Su Zhe also put down his chopsticks and consoled her: "Hurry up and eat. Your sister is a little troublemaker now."

Sheng Yu: "Oh."

Zhou Yi'an said quietly: "Uncle, Qiqi really is looking for work right now, and her credentials aren't low. You could be more lenient with her. Many people nowadays like two-dimensional culture³."

"Don't speak up for her either." Su Zhe said: "She's just a little troublemaker now. Too spoiled."

Zhou Yi'an: "..."

She chose to shut up.

In the past when they argued, Su Meiqi would let things go in one ear and out the other. Su Zhe would say a few words and that would be the end of it.

Footnotes:

¹ Comic convention (漫展, mànzhǎn): Short for "manga/anime convention," events where fans of anime, manga, and related media gather. Attendees often dress in cosplay (costume play), which explains Su Meiqi's unusual hairstyle.

² RT: Likely refers to a prestigious design competition or organization mentioned earlier in the story. The acronym stands for a specific design institution that awards emerging designers.

³ Two-dimensional culture (二次元, èr cì yuán): Literally "two-dimensional," this term refers to anime, manga, and related subcultures in Chinese internet slang. It encompasses the world of animation, comics, games, and cosplay—as opposed to "three-dimensional" (三次元) which refers to the real world.